

Article Review: Updating National Standards for Drinking-Water: A Philippine Experience

Introduction

The article "Updating National Standards for Drinking-Water: a Philippine Experience" by Lomboy and colleagues examines how the Philippines revamped its drinking-water quality standards in 2016. This wasn't just a simple update - the Department of Health (DOH) recognized that the old standards from 2007 were no longer adequate for the country's evolving water challenges. The researchers document the entire journey of creating new Philippine National Standards for Drinking-Water (PNSDW), showing how the country worked to catch up with international best practices, especially those recommended by the World Health Organization. What makes this study particularly interesting is its focus on creating water quality standards that work in the Philippine context - balancing scientific rigor with what's practically achievable for local water providers and communities.

Summary of Key Points

The researchers found some significant changes in how the Philippines now approaches water quality testing. The biggest change is probably how they organized everything into three categories: mandatory, primary, and secondary parameters. Think of mandatory parameters as the absolute must-haves - these are ten specific tests that every water provider in the country must do, no exceptions. These include checking dangerous bacteria like *E. coli*, heavy metals like arsenic and lead, and basic things like pH levels and how clear the water looks. The government picked these ten based on what's most likely to make people sick and what labs can actually test for.

Beyond these basic ten, there are 55 primary parameters that come into play depending on where the water source is located. Then there are 11 secondary parameters that deal more with how the water tastes, smells, or looks - important for getting people to actually drink it, but not immediately dangerous. What's really interesting is that the new standards don't just focus on regular situations. They added special sections for emergencies like after typhoons, standards for those water refilling stations you see everywhere, and even tied some requirements to the UN's development goals.

The way they went about updating these standards was thorough. They set up a working group with government people and water experts, then spent almost a year from February to November 2015 holding meetings and workshops. They didn't just stay in Manila either - they went to different regions to get input from local communities and water providers who have to follow these rules.

Assessment of Strengths and Weaknesses

Strengths

What impressed me most was how they made sure to talk to everyone who would be affected by these new standards. They didn't just sit in an office and write rules - they went out and asked water companies, government regulators, local officials, and even WHO experts what they thought. This kind of approach is crucial because these people are the ones who have to live with whatever standards get created. The risk-based approach they used also makes a lot of sense. Instead of testing for everything

under the sun, they focused on what's most likely to actually harm people or show up in Philippine water sources. This is way more practical than the old approach and helps smaller water providers focus their limited resources on what matters most.

I also appreciate how they thought ahead about emergencies. Living in a country that gets hit by typhoons regularly, having specific water quality standards for disaster situations is really smart. The fact that they learned from Typhoon Haiyan's experience shows they're paying attention to real-world events, not just theoretical scenarios. Another good move was recognizing that water refilling stations are everywhere now. A lot of people get their drinking water from these places, so it makes sense to have specific standards for them rather than trying to force them into rules designed for big water utilities.

Weaknesses

However, the study isn't without its problems. The biggest issue, which the authors themselves admit, is that the Philippines doesn't have a good database of water quality information. This is a pretty big deal because how can you know what to test for if you don't know what's actually in the water across different parts of the country? The researchers had to rely mostly on international guidelines and expert opinions, which is fine, but it might not capture what's unique about Philippine water sources. The radiological testing requirement also seems problematic. The authors suggest sending samples to overseas labs, but that sounds expensive and time-consuming. For a small water provider in a remote area, this could be a real burden. It makes me wonder if they fully thought through the practical implications.

What's also missing is a clear picture of how much all this will cost. The new standards sound great on paper, but if they're too expensive for smaller water providers to follow, then what's the point? A cost-benefit analysis would have been really helpful here. The methodology was solid in terms of getting input from people, but I think they could have done more actual field testing of their proposed parameters. Most of their decisions seem based on meetings and discussions rather than real-world validation of whether these parameters actually make sense for different types of water sources in the Philippines.

Critical Analysis

This research discusses something really important for public health in the Philippines. When you think about it, nine years is a long time to go without updating water quality standards, especially when new pollutants are emerging and treatment technologies are evolving. The timing was definitely right for this update. What I find most interesting is how they tried to balance international best practices with local realities. It's easy to copy standards from developed countries, but what works in the US or Australia might not be practical here. The risk-based approach they adopted is smart because it forces you to think about what's actually happening on the ground rather than just following a checklist.

The emergency standards part really hits home for me. After watching what happened during Typhoon Haiyan and other disasters, it's clear that our regular water quality rules don't always apply when infrastructure is damaged and people are desperate for clean water. Having specific guidelines for these situations could literally save lives. I also think their recognition of water refilling stations is pretty forward-thinking. Let's be honest - a huge chunk of Filipinos get their drinking water from these places,

not from traditional water utilities. Instead of ignoring this reality, they worked it into their standards, which shows they're paying attention to how people actually live.

Conclusion and Recommendations

Overall, this article documents what I think is a significant achievement for public health policy in the Philippines. The updated water quality standards represent a real step forward from the 2007 version, and the way they went about creating them - involving lots of stakeholders, using a risk-based approach, thinking about emergencies - all of that shows they were serious about making something that would actually work.

The three-tier system they came up with seems practical. Having those ten mandatory parameters that everyone has to test for creates a baseline level of safety, while the primary and secondary parameters let different water providers focus on what's relevant to their specific situation. That's the kind of flexibility that makes sense in a country as diverse as the Philippines but let's be real about the challenges ahead – the biggest one is probably building up our water quality monitoring infrastructure. Without better data collection systems, it's going to be hard to know if these new standards are actually making a difference. The government needs to invest in this and maybe partner with universities or research institutions to help fill the gaps. I also think there needs to be more support for smaller water providers. These new standards sound great, but if a small rural water system can't afford to follow them, then we haven't really solved anything. Maybe there could be some kind of graduated implementation timeline or financial assistance programs.

For future research, I'd love to see studies that track how well these standards are actually being implemented and whether they're having the intended health impacts. It would also be interesting to see how other countries in Southeast Asia are handling similar challenges - maybe there are lessons we can learn from each other. The bottom line is that this work gives us a solid foundation, but the real test will be in the implementation. Success will depend on having adequate funding, proper training for water providers and regulators, and ongoing monitoring to make sure the standards stay relevant as conditions change.